



ON THE DARK SIDE A police surveillance photograph shows Muslims of African origin training for militant activity in a camp in Cumbria, north-west England

Al Qaeda leaders, possibly Ayman al-Zawahiri himself.

Yet, this most recent plot was different. The men behind it were neither home-grown Brits nor, as far as is currently known, had they travelled to Pakistan. The amateurishness of the bombs and the desperation of the attempted suicide attack on the airport are far from the meticulously prepared Al Qaeda attacks of the late 1990s or even 9/11 itself. Also, the plotters are well-educated doctors and engineers. This is less surprising than one would think. A series of studies in recent years has shown it is not the poor and marginalised who become militants. One study of 400 profiles by American specialist Marc Sageman showed that over two-thirds had university degrees. "Terrorists are usually seen as being ignorant and immature, as coming from a poor background and a broken family, with no skills and no family or responsibility. Little of this is true for Al Qaeda members and supporters," he said.

Analysts also point out that movements such as the Muslim Brotherhood, Pakistan's Jamaat-e-Islami and the Tablighi Jamaat, have their support bases in the urban lower middle classes. "Though there are

other examples of virtually destitute asylum-seekers, reformed drug addicts and juvenile delinquents drawn into the world of radical Islam, they are the exception rather than the rule," said one senior British police officer. "In fact, the profiles of contemporary Islamic militants and violent leftwing (or indeed rightwing) activists over the decades have a lot in common."

Yet, though it looks increasingly like the Doctor's Plot which relied on a small and tight-knit group of men who had not been in the UK for more than a couple of years, few doubt that the main threat remains home-grown. Last week, an MI5 map of networks, leaked to a newspaper, revealed around 80 suspected terror networks—from a total of 219 such suspected networks in Britain—in and around the city of Birmingham. Eliza Manningham-Buller, former head of MI5, said there was a "pressing demand" for the police to create a network of spies from within the Muslim population to help gather intelligence on suspects and plots, as networks "scattered across the country" were thought to be plotting up to 30 attacks at any point of time.

The idea of Muslim spies is less far-

fetched than it might once have been. The events of the last week have marked a change in the attitudes of some British Muslim leaders. With Blair now preparing for his new job as special peace envoy in the Middle East, some are finding it easier to reconcile themselves to the demands of the new team at Number 10, careful to designate no one as a minority, to show more solidarity. Declaring that "condemnation is not enough", leaders of the Muslim Council of Britain (MCB), which has 400 affiliate organisations and is

Britain's most influential Muslim umbrella group, appealed to all Muslims last week to work with the police. Muhammad Abdul Bari, MCB's secretary-general, said the current crisis meant that issues of conflict between the Government, police and Muslim communities—who have clashed in the past over anti-terrorist incidents and foreign policy—needed to be put to one side. "When the house is on fire, the concern must be not to blame each other, but to put the fire out," he said.

His call found an echo in the words of Admiral Sir Alan West, the UK's new security supreme, who called for Britons to be "a little bit un-British". "Britishness does not normally involve snitching or talking about someone," he said. "I'm afraid, in this situation, anyone who's got any information should say something because the people we are talking about are trying to destroy our entire way of life." West outlined a campaign that will last half a generation, echoing the view of French analyst Olivier Roy, who talks of "a generational phenomenon". "This is not a quick thing," West said. "I believe it will take 10 to 15 years. But I think it can be done." But with British security officials saying that they "have no more gears to go up" in terms of the intensity of their response to the current threat, it is clear that it will not be done soon. ■